

HEALING POWERS

the many faces of spirituality and shamanism

The term “shamanism” refers to the spiritual practices of people in the steppe lands of Central Asia and Siberia. In these places, shamanism—the world’s oldest continuously practiced form of spiritualism, divination, and magic—dates back some 40,000 years.

Shamanism is sometimes also used as an umbrella term to cover a vast set of spiritual and magical traditions found in tribal or non-European cultures all over the world. Some academics claim that such traditions are related, and define them collectively as shamanism. Many others suggest that, despite appearing similar from an outsider’s perspective, these diverse traditions should not be grouped together: spiritual practices vary a great deal between different communities, and many practitioners do not call themselves shamans.

Bridge to the spirit world

The beliefs and practices defined by some academics as shamanistic may share basic features, such as the idea that everything in the natural world is sacred and infused with its own spiritual life, or that all natural objects exist as part of a wider divine whole. This idea of unity can also extend to time; in some cultures, the past, present, and future are thought to exist simultaneously. Accordingly, guardian or ancestral spirits may be venerated for their insight into the future, as well as wisdom from the past.

A shaman, elder, or spiritual adviser provides the link between the material and spiritual worlds: praying to spirits, channeling spirit voices, or crossing into the spirit world. Contact with the spirits might bestow prophetic powers, or the ability to protect against destructive natural forces and enemies, to ensure harvests, or to conduct the souls of the dead to the spirit world. In many places, malign spiritual interventions are believed to cause illnesses. A shaman, healer, or medicine person may invoke good spirits to counteract the evil ones, or make use of plants with curative properties.

Today, people in various cultures consult their spiritual leader or shaman before making any major decision. In some groups, these leaders are born into the role, inheriting it

◀ Ceremonial rattle

During rituals, the rhythm produced by rattles and drums can help people enter a trance. This late 18th-century ceremonial rattle, with exaggerated features and a beaklike nose, is from the northwest coast of America.



“The Great Spirit is in all things,
he is in the air we breathe.
The Great Spirit is our Father,
but the Earth is our Mother.”

BIG THUNDER (BEDAGI) WABANAKI ALGONQUIN